commissioned to track the vehicle. Dynamic surveil ance was employed to cover the electrical power that flows from the missile batteries within the vehicle and to control system pressures. Should any deviation be noticed either in voltage or in pressure, the special y designed automatic checkout system would signal “Hold”. The flight operations would then be sequenced only if the defect was rectified. The countdown for the launch started at T-36 hours. The countdown from T-7.5 minutes was to be computer control ed.

Al activities preparatory to the launch went according to schedule. We had decided to move the people living in nearby vil ages to safety at the time of the launch. This attracted media attention, and led to much controversy. By the time 20 April 1989 arrived, the whole nation was watching us. Foreign pressure was exerted through diplomatic channels to abort the flight trial, but the Indian Government stood behind us like a rock and staved off any distraction to our work. We were at T-14 seconds when the computer signal ed “Hold”, indicating that one of the instruments

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